



A GIFT FROM YOUR PIANO TEACHER

The Adult Beginner's Piano Starter Guide

7 Steps to Start the Right Way

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A NOTE FROM ME

Hello, my dear future pianist!

I'm so glad this little guide found its way to you. If you're holding it, some part of you has always wanted to play the piano — maybe since childhood, maybe since last Tuesday. Please hear this from someone who has taught hundreds of students: **it is not too late, and you don't need "talent."** You need the right first steps — and someone who truly cares that you learn properly.

Most of my students started as adults. My favorite moments as a teacher are their faces after a first real piece — that quiet "I didn't think I could do this." You can. Let me show you how, one small step at a time — warmly, and without a single scary word of jargon.

— *Masha* (Dr. Maria Pisarenko, DMA)

STEP 1

Set up right

You need an 88-key, fully **weighted** keyboard, so your fingers build real technique — plus one good method book. (I keep my exact, honest recommendations at onlinepianouniversity.com — the same ones I give my private students.)

STEP 2

Sit and hold your hands the way pianists do

Sit at about arm's length from the keys, back tall, forearms level with the keyboard. Curve your fingers as if holding a small peach, and play on your fingertips — never with flat, stiff fingers. This one habit will save you years.

STEP 3

Read the keyboard in 2 minutes

The black keys come in groups of 2 and 3. Find **C** (just left of any group of 2 black keys) and **F** (just left of any group of 3). From there you can name every white key, A–G — and the pattern repeats across the whole keyboard. That's it — you can already read the keyboard!

STEP 4

Finger numbers & your home position

In both hands, the thumb is 1 and the pinky is 5. Rest your right-hand thumb on C — that's "C position," your home base for your very first pieces.

STEP 5

Reading music, made simple

A quarter note = 1 beat, a half note = 2, a whole note = 4. You'll learn to read music as you play — not before. Please don't fall into the trap of "learning all the theory first" — music is learned at the

piano, with me beside you.

STEP 6

Your 15-minute daily practice routine

3 minutes warm-up (a simple 5-finger exercise) → 7 minutes new material (one small section, hands separately first) → 5 minutes playing something you enjoy. A little every day beats a lot once in a while — I promise.

STEP 7

Follow a real course, in order

Random videos give random progress. Follow a step-by-step path. Start my **free** Beginner Course from Lesson 1 at onlinepianouniversity.com — the same curriculum I have taught at universities for years, now free for you.

3 MISTAKES TO AVOID

The habits that hold beginners back

- Playing with flat, stiff fingers instead of curved fingertips.
- Skipping technique to rush straight into a song.
- Practicing hands together too soon — master each hand separately first.

NEW — PERSONAL FEEDBACK

Send me your playing — I'll listen

Here is something no video course can give you — except mine. When you practice a lesson from my free course (Lessons 1–5 during the pilot), you can **record yourself and send it to me**, and you'll receive detailed, personal feedback from my studio: what's already working, the one thing to fix first, and exactly how to practice it.

- **Audio alone is enough** — a simple phone recording next to your piano.
- Want feedback on your hand position too? Film **just your hands** — your face is never required.
- **Free during the pilot.** Send it at onlinepianouniversity.com/submit.html

This is how real lessons work: you play, I listen, you improve. Don't be shy about mistakes — they are exactly what feedback is for.

ABOUT YOUR TEACHER

Who is teaching you?

My story began in Siberia, where I started piano at five and played my first solo recital at seven. I was trained in the legendary Russian school of piano — at the Central Music School of the Moscow Tchaikovsky Conservatory and the Gnessin Russian Academy of Music — and later earned my Doctor of Musical Arts in Piano Performance in the USA.

- **Doctor of Musical Arts (DMA)**, Piano Performance
- **International competition prizewinner** — Paris (Sviatoslav Richter) · Rome (Chopin)
- **Concert pianist** — stages across Russia, Europe, Asia & the USA, incl. the Royal Academy of Music (London) and the Paris Conservatory
- **Steinway Top Teacher Award** · University professor
- **My students earn top marks** (ABRSM / Royal Academy) and win competitions

YOUR NEXT STEP

Ready to really play?

- **Start the free course** — Lesson 1 at onlinepianouniversity.com
- **Subscribe on YouTube** — new lessons every Tuesday & Saturday (@ONLINEPIANOUNIVERSITY)
- **Send me your playing** — free personal feedback — onlinepianouniversity.com/submit.html
- **Want personal guidance?** I teach 1-on-1 online via Zoom — onlinepianouniversity.com/lessons

Anyone can press the keys. Together, we'll make sure you really play — with a real foundation, from your very first note. I can't wait to meet you in Lesson 1.

With warmth, Masha

Dr. Maria Pisarenko, DMA · Online Piano University